

Medicine is a vocation that promises lifelong learning and the intrigue of the possibilities of future medical discoveries is appealing to me. It is driven by motivated people who desire to understand the intricacies of humans and to use this knowledge to help people and treat diseases. I am drawn to Medicine because of its unique application of science to benefit others.

During work experience, I gained a broad insight into the diverse field of Medicine by listening to doctors in different specialties. I observed a radiologist and was shown a CT scan which showed a denser white area. The patient had an acute ischaemic stroke but when the doctors induced thrombolysis, intracerebral haemorrhage occurred, resulting in death. This showed me how complex medicine can be and how the use of treatments must be balanced by their side effects. Doctors must think critically and require excellent problem-solving skills to make decisions in the best interests for patients. I improved my problem-solving skills by achieving Bronze in the Cambridge Chemistry Challenge which gave me the opportunity to apply science to solve difficult problems.

Furthermore, I completed the Observe GP course and a six weeks virtual medical placement. During a GP consultation, I saw how a doctor used a patient-first approach. She used effective communication skills to discuss the risks and benefits involved in the intervention and I witnessed the holistic approach to Medicine. Doctors consider the entire person rather than solely the symptoms of a disease, allowing them to build a rapport with patients which leads to personalised patient care. I also discussed the importance of multidisciplinary teams and the benefits of availing of the skills of other healthcare professionals such as nurses. Adopting a horizontal hierarchy ensures that common goals of looking after people are met. As Deputy Head girl, I recognise the importance of this and have developed my leadership and listening skills while working with the senior team. Working as a waitress has also improved my communication skills with people. This proved helpful during a Salter Stirling programme where I worked with other volunteers in a school to care for children with disabilities. Volunteering taught me how to work effectively in a team which will be invaluable in my medical career. While volunteering at a nursing home, I felt connected to the residents who shared their experiences with me. I was empathetic and tried to understand what they were going through. Empathy is essential in the medical profession as you must understand the emotional needs of patients as well as the physical needs.

I enjoyed the independent level of study introduced in HE+ lectures and became interested in mental disorders after attending a National Psychiatry Summer School. Reading 'The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat' by Oliver Sacks was striking because a patient with prosopagnosia cast doubts on my thoughts that the brain and the mind are synonymous. These doubts arose because although the man's brain functioned at a high level, he lacked the ability to imagine scenarios and recognise emotions. Through online research, I discovered the mind-body dualism concept. I think it is illogical to separate the brain from the mind. However, I wonder if the less tangible ideas of consciousness and emotional intelligence that are typically attributed to the mind could help explain the disconnect in the man's brain functioning. Completing an online course called 'What is a Mind' brought clarity to my ideas and helped reconcile the relationship between the physical brain and the philosophical idea of the mind. Separating these ideas would contradict the advances that have been made in the study of the brain and would also risk ignoring important aspects of the patient's identity. Medicine is challenging but I believe that improving my scientific understanding in a patient-focused environment will be worthwhile.